



CURRENT ISSUES & EVENTS

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2026 • SET A



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UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE
CURRENT ISSUES & EVENTS CONTEST
SET A • SPRING 2026

1. _____ President Andry Rajoelina was forced out of power and out of the country after a military mutiny which was the culmination of weeks of demonstrations led by young protesters referring to themselves as their nation's "Gen Z." The movement mirrors other recent protests across the world, in countries like Nepal, the Philippines, Kenya, Peru, and Indonesia.

A. Iran's	C. Madagascar's
B. France's	D. Morocco's

2. A federal judge ordered a shake-up of Google's search engine in an attempt to curb the power of what was deemed an illegal monopoly without agreeing with the government's wish to break up the company. Instead, U.S. District Judge Amit Mehta ruled that Google be forced to _____.

A. discontinue deals to make it the default search engine on devices
B. reduce the fees charged to app developers using Google Play
C. open up the company's search data to rivals
D. sell the Chrome browser to another company

3. Susan Monarez was fired from her position as director of _____ after she refused to resign. Her removal sparked the resignation of other senior officials. When it was announced that she was no longer director, her lawyers responded that she had not resigned or been fired and accused administration officials of "putting millions of American lives at risk."

A. the NSA	C. the CDC
B. USAID	D. FEMA

4. Newly confirmed Federal Reserve Governor _____ dissented from the rest of their colleagues on the central bank board at their September meeting by voting for a half-point cut rather than the quarter percentage point agreed to by the rest of the members of the Federal Reserve Board of Governors.

A. Christopher Waller	C. Lisa Cook
B. Stephen Miran	D. Michelle Bowman

5. A year after defying the norm by offering a printed version, _____ reported more than 53,000 subscribers, \$4 million more in annual revenue, and a deal to sell its papers at Barnes & Nobles.
- A. *The Athletic* C. *Reader's Digest*
B. *The Onion* D. *The Atlantic*
6. The _____ was caught off guard when President Trump discussed a 100% tariff on products that are made outside of the U.S. in May. "It's shocking and would represent a virtually complete halt of production," one insider said. "But in reality...it's too complex to enforce." Trump reasserted his commitment to the tariff in September but did not specify when or how it could be enacted.
- A. automobile industry C. furniture industry
B. movie industry D. steel industry
7. The percentage of people in the U.S. who say they consume _____ is at its lowest point in at least 86 years according to a Gallup poll. The rate of consumption showed a 13-percentage-point drop from three years ago and for the first time a majority of respondents said that moderate consumption was bad for health.
- A. alcohol C. dairy products
B. tobacco products D. beef
8. The Italian fashion designer and billionaire brand owner, _____ died at the age of 91 in early September. The icon's namesake company expanded from fashion into an empire spanning beauty, fragrance, music, sport, and even luxury hotels.
- A. Chiara Ferragni C. Giorgio Armani
B. Louis Vuitton D. Donatella Versace
9. New York Attorney General _____ asked a federal judge to dismiss a mortgage fraud case against them, calling it a vindictive and politically motivated prosecution brought at the behest of a president who regards them as an enemy. The Attorney General is accused of lying on mortgage papers to get favorable loan terms when purchasing a house in Norfolk, Virginia.
- A. Charity Clark C. Kathy Jennings
B. Letitia James D. Adam Schiff

10. The U.S. government's gross national debt surpassed a record _____ according to the Treasury Department report issued in mid-August. In January 2020, the Congressional Budget Office projected the federal debt not reaching such a level until after fiscal year 2030.
- A. \$50 trillion
B. \$19 trillion
C. \$74 trillion
D. \$37 trillion
11. Congress held its first vote on President Trump's military campaign, which according to the White House at the time of the vote, had destroyed four vessels, killed at least 21 people, and stopped narcotics traffickers. The war powers resolution would have required the president to _____ before further military strikes on the cartels could take place.
- A. seek authorization from Congress
B. open diplomatic talks
C. provide details about future attacks
D. declare a state of war
12. _____ signed a U.S.-brokered peace agreement that would move them toward a full normalization of relations. The two countries have been at odds since the late 1980s due to a dispute over the Nagorno-Karabakh region. The U.S. also gained development rights to a transit corridor through the South Caucasus to be referred to as the Trump Route for International Peace.
- A. Georgia and South Ossetia
B. Armenia and Azerbaijan
C. India and Pakistan
D. Turkey and Kurdistan
13. All of the following were results of the November 4th elections EXCEPT _____.
- A. Democrat Jay Jones was defeated in the Virginia Attorney General election after a scandal about violent text messages
B. Proposition 50 allowing redistricting to move forward in California passed with nearly two-thirds of the vote
C. Democrat Mikie Sherrill won the New Jersey gubernatorial contest by about 14%
D. Democrat Abigail Spanberger won the Virginia gubernatorial contest by about 15%
14. Russia put on a display of firepower as part of its military exercises in _____ with neighboring NATO nations on alert amid some of the highest tensions in Europe since Moscow began its full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022. Around 7,000 troops took part in the exercises, which were also held in Russia's Kaliningrad Baltic exclave and in the Baltic and Barents seas.
- A. Crimea
B. Belarus
C. Moldova
D. Hungary

15. After two decades of anticipation and countless delays, the Grand _____ Museum is finally open. It is a centerpiece of the government's drive to boost the tourist industry. The \$1 billion mammoth facility is poised to become the world's largest museum dedicated to a single civilization with over 50,000 artifacts detailing the life of the country's ancient past.
- A. Iraqi
B. Chinese
- C. Egyptian
D. Greek
16. A massive landslide in western _____ has destroyed the village of Tarseen (Tarasin) and killed as many as 1,000 people according to local groups. Many of the victims were displaced and starving, having fled more than two years of intense fighting in the nation's civil war.
- A. Palestine
B. Myanmar
- C. Democratic Republic of Congo
D. Sudan
17. In the wake of the deadly UPS flight 2976 crash in the shipping hub of _____, the Federal Aviation Administration effectively grounded all MD-11 and MD-11F aircraft until each undergoes a thorough inspection.
- A. Chicago
B. Charlotte
- C. Louisville
D. Atlanta
18. A Wall Street Journal-NORC poll released on Labor Day revealed that the majority of U.S. adults no longer believe that _____. Respondents expressed beliefs that previous generations faced fewer challenges when purchasing homes or parenting.
- A. the government acts in their best interest
B. putting in hard work ensures financial success
C. the next generation will have a similar quality of life as their parents
D. buying a home is a better economic decision than renting
19. A lawsuit filed by Matt and Maria Raine, parents of 16-year-old Adam Raine, in California court was the first legal action accusing OpenAI of _____. It seeks damages as well as "injunctive relief to prevent anything like this from happening again."
- A. child abuse
B. invasion of privacy
- C. wrongful death
D. identity theft

20. A man from _____ was arrested in Italy on suspicion of coordinating the attacks on the Nord Stream gas pipelines according to German prosecutors. The explosions damaged three pipelines carrying gas from Russia to Europe and no one has ever taken responsibility.
- A. Moldova
B. Ukraine
- C. Belarus
D. Iran
21. The Treasury Department announced it was stopping the practice of issuing _____ for Social Security payments and most other government programs.
- A. direct deposits
B. debit cards
- C. paper checks
D. money orders
22. _____ Congress voted to remove unpopular President Dina Boluarte from office as a crime wave gripped the nation and quickly replaced her with José Jerí, the legislative body's leader. Congress requested that Boluarte come before them to defend herself, but when she did not appear they immediately voted to oust her. The vote was 124-0 for impeachment.
- A. Paraguay's
B. Bolivia's
- C. Peru's
D. Brazil's
23. Japan's Prime Minister Shigeru Ishiba announced his resignation in September due to growing pressure after a historic defeat in July's parliamentary election for his _____. It is one of the country's most successful political parties that has been in power almost continuously since its formation in 1955.
- A. Fumio Kishida Constitutional Democratic Party (CDP)
B. Japan Innovation Party (JIP)
C. Democratic Party for the People (DPP)
D. Liberal Democratic Party (LDP)
24. Brazilians protested against a bill, which could result in ex-President Jair Bolsonaro being granted amnesty. The demonstrators also expressed anger at a constitutional amendment which would make it harder to launch criminal proceedings against lawmakers. Critics dubbed it the "_____" but members of Congress said it was necessary to limit "judicial overreach."
- A. Banditry Bill
B. Amnesty Amendment
- C. Get Out of Jail Free Act
D. Constitution Killer

25. Demonstrations soared across Indonesia at the end of August as thousands took to the streets of its capital, Jakarta, and other cities a day after _____ focused on rising unemployment and inflation. Six people were killed leading to President Subianto to revoke the housing allowance and other privileges for legislators.
- A. police responded with a curfew and closed the cities film festival
 - B. a vehicle struck and killed a young taxi driver at protests
 - C. students walked out of university classes demanding new curriculum
 - D. Parliament failed to pass sweeping constitutional reforms
26. With the rallying cry of "Unpaid work won't fly," _____ flight attendants walked off the job. The workers protested not being paid for the time planes are boarding and deplaning passengers. A national labor board ordered the strikers back to work, but they refused seeking immediate negotiations.
- A. Air Canada
 - B. Southwest Airlines
 - C. KLM
 - D. Lufthansa
27. President Trump announced the U.S. government secured a 10% stake in _____ in a deal that was completed just a couple weeks after the president had depicted the company's CEO as a conflicted leader unfit for the job.
- A. NVIDIA
 - B. TikTok
 - C. Alphabet
 - D. Intel
28. A study suggests _____ effectively prolonged the lives of certain cancer patients. The study, published in the journal *Nature*, examined health records of patients who received the treatment within 100 days of starting immunotherapy for lung and skin cancer. It is believed the process awakened the body's immune system to the presence of cancer, but exactly how isn't clear.
- A. chromosomal gene therapy
 - B. cold plunge therapy
 - C. Platelet-rich plasma (PRP) injections
 - D. mRNA coronavirus vaccines
29. Vermont State Senator Sam Douglass, who took part in a group chat on Telegram in which members made racist comments and joked about gas chambers, resigned. The exchanges involved leaders and members of the _____ and some of its affiliates. A joint statement from GOP lawmakers described the comments as "unacceptable and deeply disturbing."
- A. College Republicans of America
 - B. Turning Point USA
 - C. National Rifle Association
 - D. Young Republican National Federation

30. Kenya has received official recognition from the World Health Organization for eliminating _____, or human African trypanosomiasis, as a public health concern. It is the 10th African nation to reach the goal against the disease spread by tsetse flies that is nearly always fatal without treatment.
- A. yellow fever
B. sleeping sickness
C. typhoid
D. malaria
31. The U.S. Supreme Court refused to intervene in a lower court decision that affirmed a Mississippi law requiring users to verify their _____ before using social media sites. Justice Kavanaugh wrote the law "is likely unconstitutional," but allowed it to go into effect.
- A. voter registration
B. ethnicity
C. age
D. location
32. Mexican authorities are accusing sportswear company, _____ of plagiarizing artisans in southern Mexico, alleging the new sandal design, called the Oaxaca Slip-On, is strikingly similar to the traditional Indigenous footwear known as huaraches.
- A. Adidas
B. Crocs
C. Nike
D. Puma
33. At a time when President Vladimir Putin is unable to visit more than 100 nations, out of fear he could be arrested due to warrants issued by the International Criminal Court, his trip to _____ to discuss his country's invasion of Ukraine with President Trump was possible because the U.S. is not party to the treaties governing the ICC.
- A. Dededo, Guam
B. Anchorage, Alaska
C. Honiara, Solomon Islands
D. Washington, D.C.
34. More than 1,000 silver and gold coins valued at about \$1 million have been recovered from the remains of a Spanish fleet that sank over 300 years ago off _____ Treasure Coast. The discovery was made by Captain Levin Shavers and his crew as part of the company that owns the exclusive salvage rights to the 1715 Treasure Fleet.
- A. Puerto Rico's
B. California's
C. Florida's
D. South Carolina's

35. The U.N. Security Council voted to authorize a much larger, 5,550-member international force with expanded powers to help stop escalating gang violence in _____. The resolution, co-sponsored by the U.S. and Panama, will transform the current Kenya-led multinational force into a "Gang Suppression Force" with the added power to arrest suspected gang members.
- A. Colombia
B. Haiti
C. the Philippines
D. Somalia
36. Federal prosecutors were unable to persuade a grand jury to approve a felony indictment against a man who threw a sandwich at a federal agent on the streets of _____. It was the second time in the same week that a grand jury refused to indict a person accused of a felony assault on a federal agent. The man was ultimately found not guilty of misdemeanor assault.
- A. Portland
B. Washington, D.C.
C. Los Angeles
D. Chicago
37. It came to light recently that an anonymous hacker played a crucial role in helping plaintiffs achieve a massive \$243 million verdict against _____. The company initially claimed that it could not locate data from the car involved in the wreck, but after the hacker located the data for the plaintiffs, the carmaker soon said it also found the data.
- A. Baidu
B. AutoX
C. Tesla
D. Waymo
38. Families of numerous religious denominations, as well as non-religious plaintiffs, brought a lawsuit arguing the Texas bill requiring public schools _____ charging it imposed a religious preference on their children in violation of the First Amendment.
- A. to display donated copies of the Ten Commandments
B. to set aside time for prayer and meditation at least three times a week
C. to offer Bible courses as an elective at all high school campuses
D. underline "under God" in all displays of the Texas pledge
39. In the so-called _____ economy, a large portion of the population is in financial distress being impacted by rising prices while another significant segment has strengthened its financial position benefiting from the stock market and other factors.
- A. V-shaped
B. C-shaped
C. U-shaped
D. K-shaped

40. _____ was gradually coming back online on October 2nd following a sweeping cut in cellphone and internet services that affected everything from banking to travel to aid work. “The cut was implemented without clear explanation from the...authorities and appears to have been reversed also without an explanation,” U.N. spokesperson Stéphane Dujarric told reporters.
- | | |
|----------------|-------------|
| A. Iraq | C. Pakistan |
| B. Afghanistan | D. Iran |

ESSAY PROMPT:

NOTE: Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified. Any essay that does not demonstrate a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic will be disqualified. The rankings of essays will be based primarily on how well the topic has been addressed. A focused, concise and specific essay beats a vague and rambling essay. Proper grammar and organization should be used to aid clarity, but should not be considered a major factor in scoring. Cover as many corners of the issue as practical. Avoid including personal editorialized opinions, as more than enough information on the subject has been published.

Mr. Trump used the bill signing to attack Democrats for what he called “extortion,” blaming them for harm inflicted on air travel and the loss of paychecks for federal workers. Polling, however, shows most Americans blame Republicans for the shutdown.

“I just want to tell the American people, you should not forget this,” Mr. Trump added. “When we come up to midterms and other things, don’t forget what they’ve done to our country.”

-Catie Edmondson and Zolan Kanno-Youngs reporting for The New York Times, Nov. 12, 2025

The federal government reopened in mid-November after the longest shutdown in U.S. history. The closure exposed and exacerbated political divisions in Washington and across the country, but critics from either side of the aisle questioned how it was handled and what it accomplished. Discuss the pertinent issues and events surrounding why the shutdown happened, what impacts it had, and how it eventually ended.

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ANSWER KEY

(2 points each)

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Points contestants could mention in their essay:

Causes

- On Oct. 1, Democrats in the Senate voted against a Republican-sponsored resolution to continue funding the government and countered with a bill that extended the expiring Affordable Care Act subsidies.

- The new rates were to go in effect at the beginning of 2026 with new prices being published at the start of enrollment on Nov. 1st. Premiums increased an average of 18% for the approximately 24 million using the marketplace.

- Speaker Mike Johnson adjourned the House of Representatives after passing a “clean” continuing resolution and vowed not to call the chamber back into session until the Senate approved the measure.

Impacts/Events

- Just below 700,000 federal workers were furloughed and just over 700,000 worked without pay. The White House sent over 4,000 workers layoff notices on Oct. 10th, but a federal judge issued a restraining order retracting the RIFs

- Adelita Grijalva was elected to the House from AZ in Sept., but Speaker Johnson said he would not swear her in until the shutdown ended. Democrats won significant victories in VA, NJ, and other state races on Nov. 4th leading some analysts to think a deal was more likely.

- The Dept. of Transportation announced cancellations would begin ramping up from 3% to 10% of all flights to compensate for air traffic controllers and TSA agents that were calling out due to not being paid. Delays at

major airports were already increasing before the cuts.

- SNAP benefits for over 40 million in the US were halted on Nov. 1st by the Trump administration when it decided not to access emergency funds to continue the program. A lawsuit by some cities, states, and nonprofits forced the administration to continue funding the program until the Supreme Court ordered a stay allowing the program to again be halted. The mixed messages had states scrambling to cover the gap or wait for clarity.

- President Trump met with GOP Senators to convince them to end the filibuster rule which would allow them to end the shutdown with a bare majority, but he was rebuffed.

Ending

- The House voted 222 to 209 (6 Dems voted yes and 2 GOP members voted nay) on the 43rd day of the shutdown for a spending package to re-open the federal government after 8 Democratic Senate caucus members joined with Republicans to vote 60-40.

- Layoffs were reversed and retroactive pay for all furloughed workers was mandated.

- Dem. Leader Hakeem Jeffries called for a vote in the House on extending subsidies. GOP Senate Majority Leader Thune agreed to hold a vote in December. Some Democrats began to call for Sen. Chuck Schumer to be replaced as Dem. leader

- A controversial addition allowed senators that had phone records searched by the former Special Counsel Jack Smith’s investigation into the attack on the Capitol on Jan. 6, 2021, to sue for \$500,000 per violation.